

POST INDEPENDENCE DEVELOPMENTS

INDIRA...OUR ONLY OPTION

MODULE-10

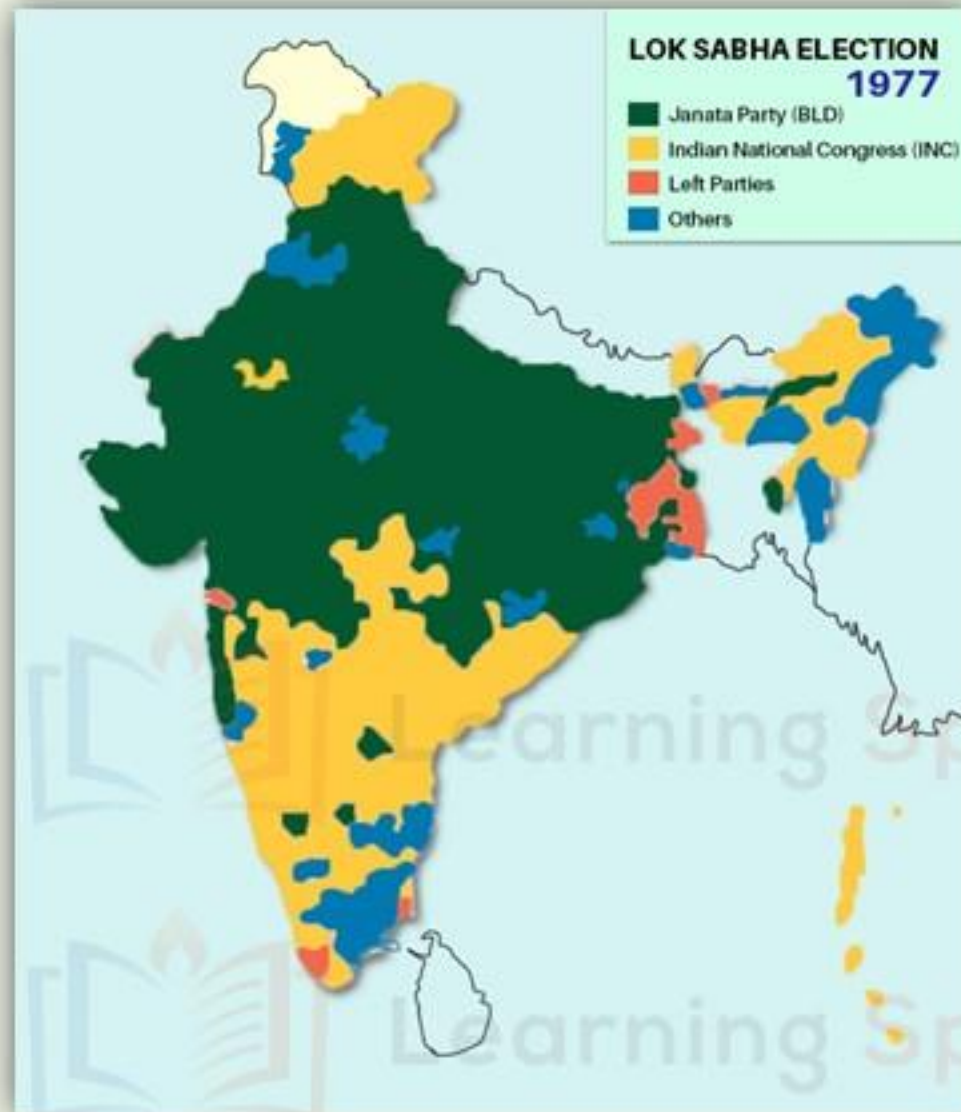


1977 ELECTIONS



- 1 In January 1977, after eighteen months of Emergency, fresh elections were announced and PM Gandhi said that normalcy had been restored.
- 2 Her opponents were being released from jails across the country.
- 3 Elections were held in March 1977.
- 4 The opposition parties came together to form the Janata Party under the leadership of Jayaprakash Narayan.
- 5 This party focused on the non-democratic character of the government and garnered public opinion against it.
- 6 At least in northern India, the elections were inevitably seen as a referendum on those policies and programmes - The relocations and displacements, forced sterilisations affected mostly the northern states.

ELECTIONS OF 1977



- 1 On the night of 20 March 1977, the election results were posted.
- 2 Both Indira Gandhi and Sanjay Gandhi and the Congress in general lost the elections but retained seats in Maharashtra, Gujarat, Orissa and southern states.
- 3 The elections had revealed a manifest regional divide, and also a divide by caste and religious affiliation.
- 4 Two groups in particular, long considered to be loyal 'vote banks' of the ruling party, had this time deserted the Congress- The Scheduled Castes under the leadership of Jagjivan Ram and Muslims because of Sanjay Gandhi's activities.

JANATA GOVERNMENT

The Sixth General Elections (1977)



For the first time since independence, Congress is voted out of power



The 1977 Elections also witnessed the utter decimation of the Swatantra Party and the Jana Sang



Janata Party won 298 out of 545 seats



Morarji Desai became the first non-Congress Prime Minister of India

1

Unlike the Congress, the Janata Party had not fought the elections under a single leader.

2

- After the results were in, a controversy arose as to who should be chosen prime minister.
- There were three contenders
 - ✓ Jagjivan Ram
 - ✓ Morarji Desai and
 - ✓ Charan Singh.

Ultimately Morarji Desai was made the Prime Minister.

JANATA GOVERNMENT



- 1 There was also lack of clarity on the policies of the new government.
- 2 The Janata leaders did not want to reject the Soviets for the Americans, but to move towards a principled equidistance from the superpowers.
- 3 The Janata government also sought to mend fences with India's neighbours.
- 4 In November 1977 India and Bangladesh signed an agreement for the sharing of the Ganga waters, which gave India 20,500 cubic feet of water during the lean season, and the latter 34,500 cubic feet. The accord was signed over the protests of the state government of West Bengal, which claimed that Calcutta port would silt up if denied adequate water.

UNDOING EXCESSES OF EMERGENCY

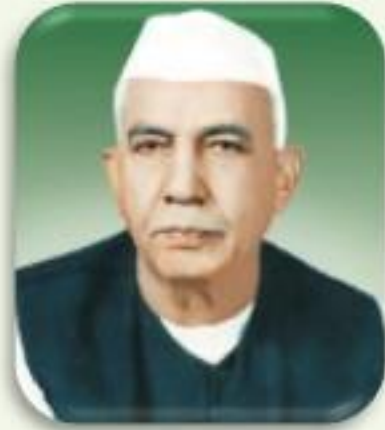
The Janata government undertook the job of repairing the constitution.

The key amendment to be overturned was the 42nd CAA. To replace its 'defiling' provisions, two fresh amendments were drafted, which reverted

- The term of Parliament and state assemblies to five years.
- The right of the Supreme Court to adjudicate on all election matters (that of the prime minister included) was restored.
- The period of President's Rule in the states was limited.
- The publication of parliamentary and legislative proceedings was made mandatory.
- The promulgation of a state of emergency was made much more difficult. Any such act had now to be approved by a two-thirds majority in Parliament, had to be renewed every six months after a fresh vote on it, and had to be in response to an 'armed rebellion' (rather than a mere 'internal disturbance', as was previously the case).

These changes were intended to curb the arbitrary powers of the executive and to restore the rights of the courts; in effect, to restore the constitution to what it was before Mrs Gandhi's emergency-era amendments.

PROBLEMS IN THE JANATA GOVERNMENT



CHAUDHARY CHARAN SINGH



- 1 In July 1979, the Socialists split from the Janata Government bringing a loss of majority in the Parliament having the Prime Minister resign.
- 2 Charan Singh convinced the President that he enjoyed majority in the House. But this was short lived as within a month, they lost support in the lower house of the Parliament. The Election Commission decided that a mid-term poll was the only solution.
- 3 The Janata party was marked by intra-party rivalries, defections, corruption charges and humiliation of its members.

EVOLUTION OF PARTY SYSTEM IN INDIA



1

- The victory of the Janata Party was a watershed moment in Indian politics.
- For the first time since Independence a party other than the Congress came to govern at the centre.
- In the states as well the Communist party in West Bengal and AIADMK in Tamil Nadu performed very well.

2

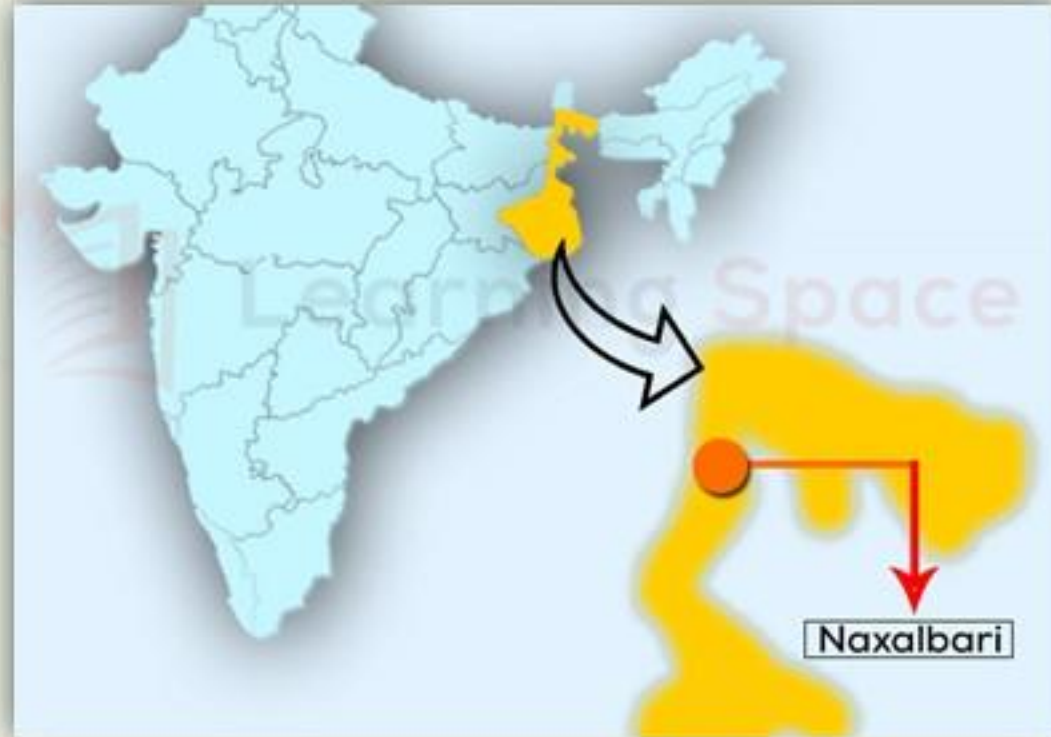
- The Indian political system was being decentred, and not just in party terms.
- For the late 1970s also witnessed the flowering of numerous 'new' social movements.
- In 1978 there was a major conference of 'socialist-feminists' in Bombay, which focused on the growing violation of women's rights.

LEGACY OF CONGRESS



- Umbrella party accommodating different ideologies and viewpoints.
- Since 1969, Congress started particular ideology - only socialist and pro-poor.
- Change in Congress, which led to opposition parties supporting non-Congressism.

NAXALBARI MOVEMENT



1 In 1967, a land dispute broke out in a Darjeeling district called Naxalbari. Naxalbari was bordered by Nepal on the West, Pakistan on the east and semi-independent kingdoms of Sikkim and Bhutan.

2 The region was known for its land plantations and had issues like land scarcity, conflicts of land, indigenous lands seeking relief from landlords.

3 This was an inequitable agrarian structure. When the CPM came to power, the peasants were hopeful that the party would address their demands.

NAXALBARI MOVEMENT

- 4 But they may not have taken the form they did had the CPM not joined the government.
- 5 Some activists, and perhaps many peasants, felt that now that their party was in power, they were at liberty to set right the feudal structure on their own.
- 6 To their surprise, the party reacted by taking the side of the forces of law and order.
- 7 By the late summer of 1967 an estimated 1,500 policemen were on duty in Naxalbari. Kanu Sanyal and his fellow leaders were in jail, while other rebels had taken refuge in the jungle.
- 8 Naxalbari quickly came to enjoy an iconic status among Indian revolutionaries. The village gave its name to the region and, in time, to anyone anywhere who would use arms to fight the Indian state on behalf of the oppressed and disinherited.

'Naxalite' became shorthand for 'revolutionary'

NAXALBARI MOVEMENT



9 The Krishak Samiti (peasants organization) owing allegiance to the CPM and led by Kanu Sanyal mobilized the rural poor. He worked in favour of the village poor.

10 In 1967, the Krishak Samiti organized demonstrations against landlords who had evicted tenants or hoarded grain. These protestors became militant and they took up arms.

11 Kanu Sanyal and his fellow mates were arrested and other rebels took refuge in the jungle.

The Naxalites were supported by the Communist China

NAXALBARI MOVEMENT



- The state and landlords used to exploit the peasants and tribals.
- The communists focused on free access to forest produce, better wages to labourers and redistribution of land.

NAXALBARI MOVEMENT IN STATES

WEST BENGAL



- In 1967 in West Bengal, there was a problem of ensuring law and order in the state.
- Riots broke out and assembly proceedings were disturbed.
- Workers gheraoed the factories demanding better wages.
- The Naxalites went on to form a new party called the Communist Party of India(Marxist-Leninist).
- The membership of CPI(ML) increased under the leadership of Charu Mazumdar who urged upon the elimination of landlords and well as the CPM cadres.
- In villages Naxalites catalysed the unrest by beheading the landlords.
- Hence the situation was of extreme lawlessness in the state.

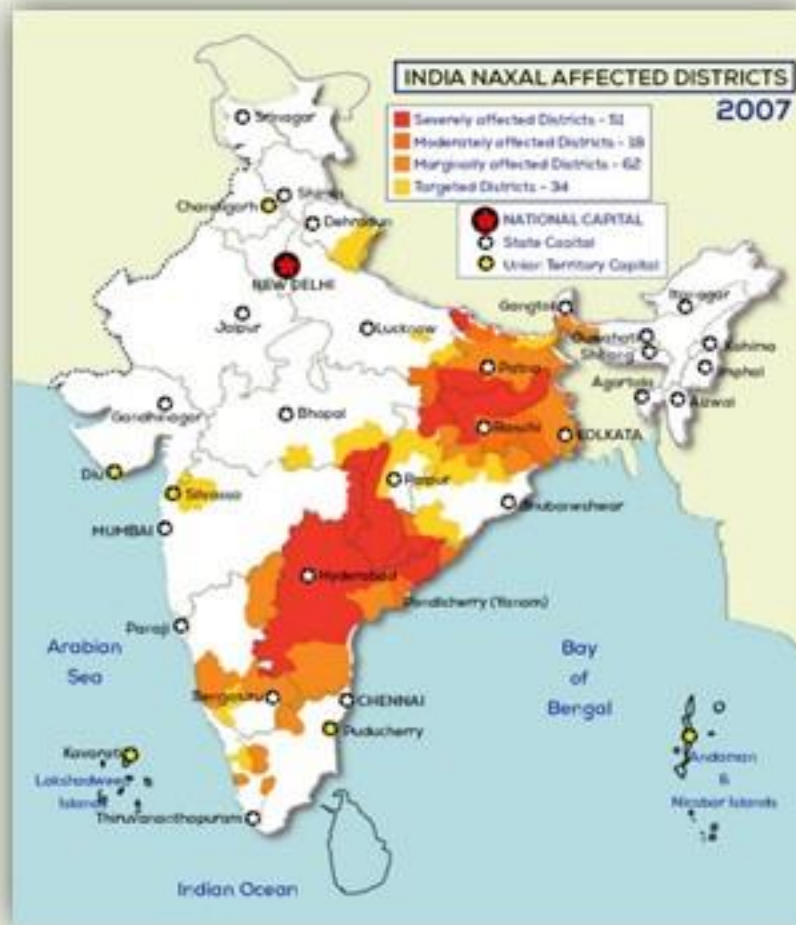
NAXALBARI MOVEMENT IN STATES

ANDHRA PRADESH

- 1 While the first sparks of revolution were being lit in Naxalbari, another group of Maoists were preparing for action in Andhra Pradesh.
- 2 The Andhra region already had similar movements which later got a character under the Naxalite movements.
- 3 The Andhra 'Naxalites' were active in two regions: Telangana, where there had been a major communist insurgency in 1946-9, and the Srikakulam district, bordering Orissa.
- 4 In both regions the areas of dispute were land and forests.
- 5 In both the main agents of exploitation were the state and landlords, the main victims peasants and (especially) tribals.
- 6 Communist mobilization focused on
 - free access to forest produce
 - better wages for labourers
 - redistribution of land.

NAXALBARI MOVEMENT IN STATES

ANDHRA PRADESH



7 In Telangana, the protestors organized the peasants and also served in the state legislature.

8 But soon they resigned from legislatures as they understood the futility of the parliamentary path.

9 Their leader Tarimala N. Reddy mobilized the peasants and asked for higher wages and for corruption to end among state officials. He trained young militants.

NAXALBARI MOVEMENT IN STATES

ANDHRA PRADESH



The state's response was to send in more police.

- 10 In Srikakulam the struggle was led by a school teacher named Vempatapu Satyanarayana.
- 11 He led the tribals in a series of labor strikes, and in seizing grain from the fields of rich farmers and redistributing it to the needy.
- 12 By the end of 1967 the landlords had sought the help of the police, who came in and arrested hundreds of protesters.
- 13 Satyanarayana and his men now decided to take to arms. The houses of landlords and moneylenders were raided and their records and papers burnt.

ASSAM



- 1 Assam shared borders with West Bengal and several states of the northeast, as well as with the countries of Bangladesh and Bhutan.
- 2 Assamese was the state language, but Bengali was also widely spoken. There was a long history of hostility between the speakers of the two languages.
- 3 Bengalis had dominated the middle and lower rungs of the colonial administration.
- 4 They exercised great authority and power over the local Assamese.

DOMINATION OF BENGALIS



- Beginning in the late nineteenth century, land-hungry Bengali peasants had begun to move into the forests and lowlands of Assam.
- After Independence this migration continued, accelerating whenever political instability or economic crisis affected East Bengal or, as it later became, Bangladesh
- The Assamese feared cultural subordination at the hands of the Bengali middle class, and demographic conquest at the hands of the Bengali peasantry.

RIGHTS OF ASSAMESE



1

There were episodic riots in the 1950s and 1960s aimed at driving the immigrants back to where they came from. However, it was only from the late 1970s that these sentiments were transmuted into a widespread social movement.

2

The key organization in this transformation was the All-Assam Students Union (AASU).

3

From 1979, the AASU led hundreds of strikes and processions intended to press the central government to clear their homeland of the infiltrators. Apart from culture and demography, AASU argues that the economy of Assam was manifestly dominated by outsiders.

4

The rich tea plantations of the state were mostly owned by firms based in London or Calcutta.

5

Local trade and commerce was controlled by Marwaris from Rajasthan.

PROTESTS IN ASSAM



1 The movement had developed other dangerous strains – anti-Bengali, anti-Left, anti-Muslim, anti-non-Assamese, and slowly but discernibly, even anti-Indian.

2 Several Bengalis were attacked and their homes burnt. But the central government was also targeted.

3 Railway tracks were uprooted.

4 They were even successful in blocking the flow of oil, forcing the government to declare the pipeline and the land extending up to half a kilometre on either side of it a 'protected area'.

5 Ultimately the army had to be called in to restore oil supplies from Assam to a refinery in distant Bihar.

6 The AASU wanted all migrants who came in after 1951 to be removed from the voters' list and deported.

GOVERNMENT RESPONSE



- 1 The government of India thought this struck at the federal principle, violating the freedom of citizens to move from one part of the country to another.
- 2 The movement, led by All Assam Students Union and the All Assam Gana Sangram Parishad, ultimately compelled the government to identify and expel illegal immigrants.
- 3 The parliament passed the Illegal Migrants (Determination by Tribunals) Act (IM-DT) in October 1983 and began to implement it in Assam.
- 4 By August 1985, it was decided that the immigrants who had entered illegally after January 1966 were to be detected, deported and disfranchised for 10 years.

BHARATIYA JANATA PARTY

During the Janata regime, the communal temperature had begun to rise alarmingly. The Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh's strength and influence increased



- In 1979 there was a major riot in the steel town of Jamshedpur; a judicial inquiry ordered by the government concluded that the RSS 'had a positive hand in creating a climate which was most propitious for the outbreak of communal disturbances'.
- After the Janata party's rout in the 1980 elections, its Jana Sangh members broke away to form a party of their own.
- They called it the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)- more a distinct political party to represent and advance the 'Hindu' interest.
- There were major Hindu-Muslim riots in several parts of the country. A simple clash would turn out to be a holy war between two religions.

INDIRA GANDHI BACK TO POWER



1 The 1980 elections marked the 'end of ideology' in Indian politics. Previous polls were fought and won on the planks of democracy, socialism, secularism and non-alignment.

2 In 1980, however, Gandhi spoke not of the abolition of poverty but of her ability to rule. Janata could not hold together a government.

3 There were shortages of basic consumer goods, attributed naturally to the party in power.

INDIRA GANDHI BACK TO POWER



4 Though Indira Gandhi's image was poor, the opposition did not have an image or a policy at all.

5 The 1980 elections brought back Indira Gandhi to power.

6 After Sanjay Gandhi's death in a plane crash, in August 1980 pressure was mounted on Rajiv Gandhi to enter politics. Nine months later Rajiv Gandhi was elected an MP from his brother's old constituency, Amethi.

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